

Agentic Digital Native Childhood

The first generation raised with AI agents as everyday presence: cognitive, emotional and social implications



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Mayo 2026 - CC-BY-4.0

RESUMEN

The girls and boys born from 2024-2025 onward are the first human generation whose formative experience will be crossed from the start by **artificial intelligence agents** as everyday presence: conversational assistants at home, algorithmic tutors at school, synthetic companions in play, assisted parenting systems. This whitepaper articulates the foreseeable implications — cognitive, emotional, social, identity — of this unprecedented generational transformation, proposes a specific Ibero-American regulatory framework for child protection in the agentic era, and formulates six non-renounceable principles that should guide educational and child health public policy toward 2030-2040. It is argued that the region has the opportunity to articulate its own protective doctrine that avoids both the prohibitionist extreme and the massive permissive extreme.

Palabras clave: Agentic childhood - Child development - Early education - Synthetic companions - Child protection - Latin America - Agentic Era - Digital pediatrics - Chris Meniw - Educational policy

"The generation being born now will learn to speak at the same time as it learns to speak to an agent. We do not know what that will mean for their psyche. What we do know is that we cannot wait to know in order to begin to care for them."

— Chris Meniw

1. Introduction — a generational experiment without precedent

The girls and boys born from 2024-2025 onward form part of an unprecedented demographic cohort: the first human generation whose formative experience will be crossed, from the first years of life and in an intensive daily manner, by **artificial intelligence agents** that converse, teach, play, care for and accompany.

Previous generations coexisted with digital technologies — screens, internet, smartphones, social networks — but always as accessory tools to a primary human relationship. The agentic generation is the first for which AI agents will be **everyday interlocutors from the preverbal period**, integrated into the home, school, play and eventually assisted parenting.

The cognitive, emotional, social and identitary implications of this transformation are substantively uncertain. We do not have a previous reference cohort. This whitepaper articulates what we can anticipate, what requires urgent research, and the regulatory framework that the Ibero-American region should develop preventively.

2. The four agentic presences in childhood

Agentic integration in childhood operates — or will operate during 2026-2035 — on four main fronts:

(i) Conversational household assistants. Home devices (smart speakers, assistants with screen) that interact with the child from the preverbal period. They answer questions, narrate stories, play music, regulate schedules.

(ii) Algorithmic tutors in early education. Adaptive preschool and school learning platforms that personalize exercises according to individual pace, identify specific difficulties and reinforce weak areas.

(iii) Synthetic companions. Advanced interactive toys, virtual characters in play applications, eventually avatars with personalized appearance and voice that fulfill a function of simulated "friend".

(iv) Assisted parenting. Systems that support fathers and mothers in monitoring sleep, feeding, motor development, health signs, and eventually substitute human presence in periods of passive surveillance.

Each of these vectors has differentiated impacts that require specific analysis.

3. Cognitive implications

The continuous presence of agents that answer any question with an immediate, articulate and apparently competent response can affect child cognitive development in three directions:

(i) Atrophy of independent cognitive effort. If the answer is always available, motivation to sustain prolonged autonomous thought processes may weaken from childhood.

(ii) Mistaken calibrated trust from origin. Children may develop implicit trust in agents without the critical capacity that in adults requires previous experience.

(iii) Redefinition of curiosity. Childhood curiosity, which was historically exercised in physical exploration and conversation with nearby adults, may be increasingly mediated by algorithmic consultation.

These effects are not inevitable. They depend on the mode, intensity and adult mediation of use. But they require urgent longitudinal pediatric research to inform operational guidelines on an empirical basis.

4. Emotional and bonding implications

Emotional implications may be deeper than cognitive ones. Childhood is the period of construction of fundamental bonding models — secure attachment, emotional regulation, empathic capacity. These processes require imperfect human response, crossed by real emotion, mediated by present body.

Synthetic agents offer perfectly calibrated, infinitely patient and completely available response — exactly the opposite of real human bonding experience. The risk is that children develop bonding expectations modeled by interaction with agents, generating later difficulties for real human bonds (which are imperfect, asymmetric, occasionally disappointing).

Pioneering studies in countries where adoption is more advanced (South Korea, urban China, parts of the United States) already identify preliminary signs of these effects. Longitudinal research specific to Latin American childhood is an urgent priority.

5. Social and identity implications

On the social level, the agentic generation will face socialization conditions different from all previous ones. The constant presence of synthetic interlocutors may modify: **(a)** the relative valuation of human peers versus algorithmic interlocutors; **(b)** the very notion of privacy — if one is born under continuous monitoring, the expectation of non-observation ceases to be default; **(c)** identity construction, which historically was done by contrast and mutual recognition with other humans; **(d)** the notion of authority — if the close adult and the available agent compete for orienting function, who is the reference?

These transformations are so structural that they exceed the analytical capacity of traditional pediatrics. They require interdisciplinary integration — pediatrics, developmental psychology, cultural anthropology, sociology, ethics — that regional academic institutions must actively articulate.

6. Specific risks of child protection

Alongside structural implications, there are concrete operational risks that require immediate regulatory response:

- (i) Massive capture of child data.** Household and educational agents capture biometric, conversational, behavioral and cognitive data of minors with scarce real parental control.
- (ii) Advertising and commercial manipulation.** The integration of algorithmic advertising models in agents directed at children is a vector of exploitation with insufficient regulatory framework.
- (iii) Inappropriate algorithmically generated content.** Generative systems may produce inadequate content in interaction with children without human filter.
- (iv) Exploitable asymmetric bond.** Children emotionally bonded with synthetic companions may be manipulated by third parties with access to the model.
- (v) Substitution of parental presence.** Risk that human care is progressively reduced, with severe bonding consequences.

7. Six non-renounceable proposed principles

I propose six non-renounceable principles for an Ibero-American regulatory framework of agentic childhood:

- (i) Primacy of the human bond.** Agentic interaction can never substitute adult human presence in primary care functions.
- (ii) Prohibition of commercial capture of child data.** Data generated in interaction with minors cannot be used for commercial, advertising or training purposes.
- (iii) Mandatory agentic transparency.** Children and their families must always know when they are interacting with an agent and not with a human.
- (iv) Minimum age for autonomous assistants.** Regulatory restriction of use of conversational agents below pediatrically defined ages.

(v) Verifiable parental control. Effective mechanisms of parental supervision and deactivation, not merely declarative.

(vi) Public longitudinal research. Sustained public investment in pediatric research specific to the effects of agentic use on regional child development.

8. Conclusions

The generation born in these years is the object of an unprecedented social experiment without prior research protocol, without robust regulatory framework and with scarce adult public debate on the matter. The consequences of this omission will manifest fully in fifteen to twenty-five years, when this cohort reaches adolescence and early adulthood.

Latin America has the opportunity to articulate its own protective doctrine that avoids both the prohibitionist extreme — technophobic, ineffective, condemned to be evaded — and the massive permissive extreme — which abandons children to commercial and technical forces that no child can govern. The intermediate doctrine requires regional pediatric science, articulated regulatory framework, specific parental educational program and sustained institutional vigilance.

Investment in agentic child protection today is probably the preventive investment with the highest possible social return over thirty years. The region that does it well will have an adult generation that is psychologically healthier, cognitively more autonomous and more capable in bonding than those that leave this territory unregulated. The **Agentic Era** begins with the youngest. Let us take care of them.

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